

Demo day: present your launch package to the room

Week 10, Lecture 1 · Design for Builders: Ship Beautiful Products as a Founder

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- How to structure a five-minute design presentation
- Defending choices with course vocabulary
- Receiving critique without getting defensive
- Iterating in public: taking notes and moving on

Part 1: structuring a design presentation

The five-minute design walkthrough

A capstone presentation has one job: show that every decision was made, not just made up.

- Lead with the product, not the process
- Show the brand sheet first (anchors the visual language for everything that follows)
- Walk landing page, then app screens, then marketing assets
- Name three decisions you made and why you made them

If you run out of time, cut process. Never cut the decisions.

The decision anatomy

Every design decision has the same structure:

1. What you chose
2. What the alternative was
3. Why this one, not that one (using a principle from the course)

Bad: "I used blue because I like blue."

Good: "I used a blue accent against a neutral-900 background because the contrast ratio clears WCAG AA at all text sizes and the hue reads as trusted without being generic."

One sentence per decision. No apologies.

What to show, in what order

Surface	What you show	Time
Brand sheet	Logo lockup, palette, type system	1 min
Landing page	Hero, social proof, features, CTA on the grid	1.5 min
App screens	Five connected screens sharing one component library	1.5 min
Marketing assets	App Store screenshots at thumbnail size, OG image	1 min

Total: five minutes. Keep a timer visible. Reviewers stop listening at six.

Part 2: defending choices

The vocabulary you earned

Ten weeks of work gave you a specific vocabulary. Use it.

When challenged on a color choice, reach for: hue, chroma, contrast ratio, semantic token, brand vs UI color.

When challenged on a type choice, reach for: type scale, x-height, measure, line-height, typeface pairing.

When challenged on layout, reach for: 8-point grid, spacing token, visual hierarchy, CRAP principles.

A vague question deserves a precise answer.

How to answer "why that choice?"

The reviewer is not attacking your taste. They are testing whether you know what you built.

A strong answer has three parts:

- Name the constraint or principle you were working within
- State what the choice achieves against that constraint
- Acknowledge the trade-off you accepted

Example: "The tight line-height on the hero headline (1.1) reduces the visual stack height so the CTA stays above the fold on a 768px screen. The trade-off is that long headlines can become hard to read, so I capped the headline at twelve words."

What you are not obligated to defend

You do not have to defend every pixel. Choose three decisions you can defend with precision and say "I'm happy to dig into any of these."

Design is not a deposition. You are showing that your process was intentional. You are not proving that your choices are the only possible correct choices.

If a reviewer's note is valid and you know it, say so: "That's right, the spacing on that card is off by 4px. I'll fix it." This earns more trust than defending the mistake.

Part 3: receiving critique

What critique is and is not

Critique is: a question about whether the design achieves its stated goal.

Critique is not: a personal assessment of your ability or taste.

The fastest way to make critique useful is to hear it as a question about the work, not about you.

"The hero feels busy" translates to: "I cannot tell what the single most important visual element is on this page." That is a visual hierarchy question. You know how to answer it.

The note-taking discipline

When you receive a critique, write it down immediately. Do not explain. Do not qualify. Just write.

Write the note in the form: "[Element], [observation], [principle at stake]"

Example: "Hero image, competes with headline for eye-entry, visual hierarchy"

After section, you will have a list of specific, principle-tagged notes. You can act on them or decide not to. But you will not be acting on a vague memory of someone's reaction.

The only acceptable responses during critique

- "Got it." (You wrote it down.)
- "Can you say more about which element?" (You need to identify the specific element before you can act.)
- "Is that a hierarchy problem or a spacing problem?" (You are narrowing to the right principle.)

Do not defend during the note-taking phase. Defense comes when you decide which notes to act on, alone, after section.

Part 4: iterating in public

Iteration is a skill, not a character trait

The ability to hear a note and improve the work quickly is one of the most useful skills in product development. It is also trainable.

The section this week is a structured environment for practicing exactly this. You will receive notes from two different reviewers. You will have fifteen minutes to act on some of them. The goal is not to solve everything. The goal is to practice the loop: hear, choose, change, document.

The revision decision

For each note you receive, you have three options:

1. Act on it: the note is valid and the fix is within scope of this session
2. Defer it: the note is valid but the fix requires more than fifteen minutes
3. Decline it: you disagree with the note and can articulate why

All three are valid. The only wrong answer is acting on a note you don't understand, or ignoring a note you know is right because fixing it feels like admitting something.

Document your decision for every note. "Fixed," "Deferred: need to rethink the whole grid," or "Declined: the tight leading is intentional for this headline length."

What to document in your Figma file

Create a text frame on your cover page labeled "Section feedback log." For each note you received:

- Source (Reviewer A or B)
- The note, verbatim
- Your decision (act / defer / decline)
- If acted on: what you changed
- If deferred or declined: one sentence of reasoning

This document is part of your final capstone submission. It shows that you engaged with the feedback, not just the design.

Take-aways

1. Structure your presentation to show decisions, not process: brand sheet, landing page, app screens, assets in that order.
2. Every defensible design choice has the same three parts: the constraint, what the choice achieves, and the trade-off accepted.
3. Critique is a question about the work. Hear it as a precise question about visual hierarchy, spacing, or contrast, and answer it in those terms.
4. Write every note down before you evaluate it. The evaluation comes later.
5. Document your revision decisions: acted on, deferred, or declined, with a one-sentence reason for each.



The question is not whether the design is perfect. The question is whether every decision in it was intentional.

, Design for Builders, Week 10

What's next

- **Section this week:** Mutual critique. Bring your complete launch package. Two peer reviews, fifteen minutes of revision, written feedback log.
- **Reading:** Week 10 reading covers the course spine, the design-to-code handoff, and what to keep building after the course ends.
- **Lecture 2:** Design to code: tokens, component specs, and the Figma-to-Tailwind pipeline.
- **CAPSTONE due:** Launch package submitted before section starts.